Chora
Monastery
Church/Kariye



Week 3

- Byzantion/Byzantium
  BC.667?-AD. 330
- Constantinople: 330-1453
- İstanbul/Ottoman's
  Istanbul: 1453-1923
- İstanbul: 1923-

- B.C.: 695?-667?-660?: Megarans
- The sieges and short-term dominance of the Dorians, Ionians, Persians (Darius I-5th century BC) and Spartans
- BC. 146: Roman as dependent city status
- 196: Septimus Severus' destruction of Byzantion
- 330-395: Roman Empire
- 395-1204 ve1261-1453: Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Empire
- Latin Empire: 1204-1261
- Ottoman Empire: 1453-1923

In this course, when we study the history of the city, we consider its name (mostly) used in that period. Of course, the city had other names as well, which were mentioned in the first lecture.
This week, we will look at what happened after the city was opened by Constantine as the capital of the Roman Empire.

Constantinople, the capital of Rome

- The city was officially founded on May 11, 330, after a signifing ceremony that started from the Hippodrome and ended at Constantine Forum (Çemberlitaş).
- The capital of the Roman Empire was now moved to Istanbul. During this period, it would be called Constantinople due to Constantine's name.
- In 395, 65 years before the Roman Empire split into two, Istanbul became the capital of the Roman Empire.
- Until this date, 7 emperors reigned in Istanbul:
  - Constantine I
  - Constantine II
  - Julien L'Apostat
  - Jovien
  - Valens
  - Gratien
  - Thedosios I

Constantinople, the capital of Rome

- From 330 onwards, the Roman Empire was a state with two capitals: Rome in the West and Constantinople in the East. However, Emperor Constantine spent a significant part of his time in his new capital, Constantinople.



- Constantinople was established as a '**world capital**' from the very beginning.
  - The civilized world of Late Antiquity consisted of the Mediterranean basin, which was ruled by the Roman Empire. The capital of the Roman Empire also meant the capital of the World. The city was designed in accordance with this vision, almost reconstructed from scratch, and the leading lines of this initial design have survived to the present day.

Constantinople, the capital of Rome: New religion

- Constantine, as a ruler who saw that the western lands and the city of Rome were under threat from the Franks, Germans and other Northern European tribes, whom the Romans called 'barbarians', and was concerned about this, must have been looking for a more secure base and strong support for the empire. He must have thought that the safer lands were in the eastern half of the empire and that the social support he needed was in the Christian communities.
- **With the Edict of Milan** ***(Milano fermanı)*** **issued in 313, he legalized the Christian religion as one of the equal religions of the Roman Empire**.
- Constantine tried to legitimize the tolerance he showed to this new religion by associating it with the victory he won at the Milvian Bridge in 312, and said that he won the victory with a divine sign that manifested to him.
- **Although he was baptized only on his deathbed, his interest in Christianity was quite close.** Because he also desired to be the leader of Christians.
- **He tried to form Christian unity in religious matters by convening the First Ecumenical Council in Nicaea between May 20 and June 19, 325.** Approximately 300 bishops from all over the empire attended this Council, where the foundations of the Christian church was laid.
- There is no definite information as to whether Constantine, who legalized Christianity, had a church built in his new capital.

Constantinople, the capital of Rome

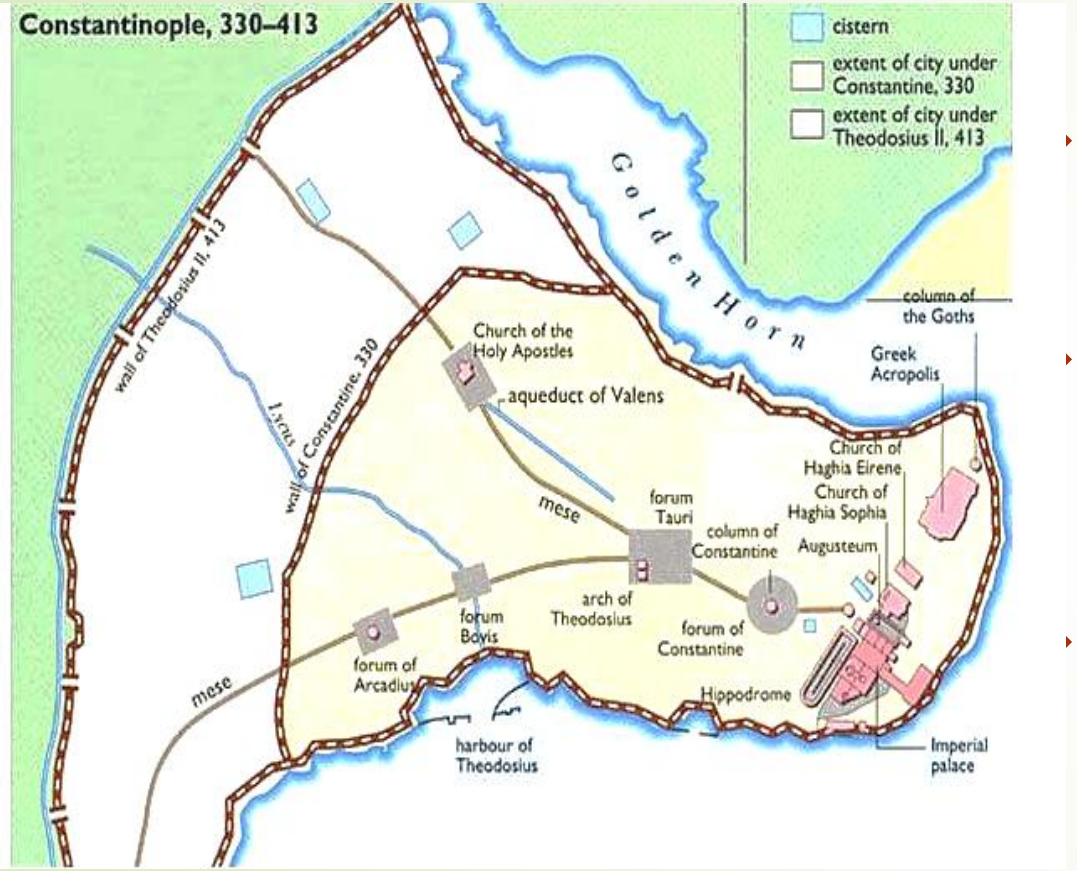
- **After Constantine, the city continued to develop within the framework of the design he created.**
  - streets were extended to the Theodosian walls, new forums were built, the city was equipped with many churches and monasteries, especially the episcopal church Hagia Sophia, the water problem was solved with aqueducts and cisterns, and new ports were added to the city formation.
- **Constantinople, founded in the mid-4th century, bears the characteristic features of a Roman city.**
- By the 6th century, the city had become the most developed city in the Roman world in terms of population density and urbanism.



The city and its structures during the Constantine period



The borders of the city of Constantine

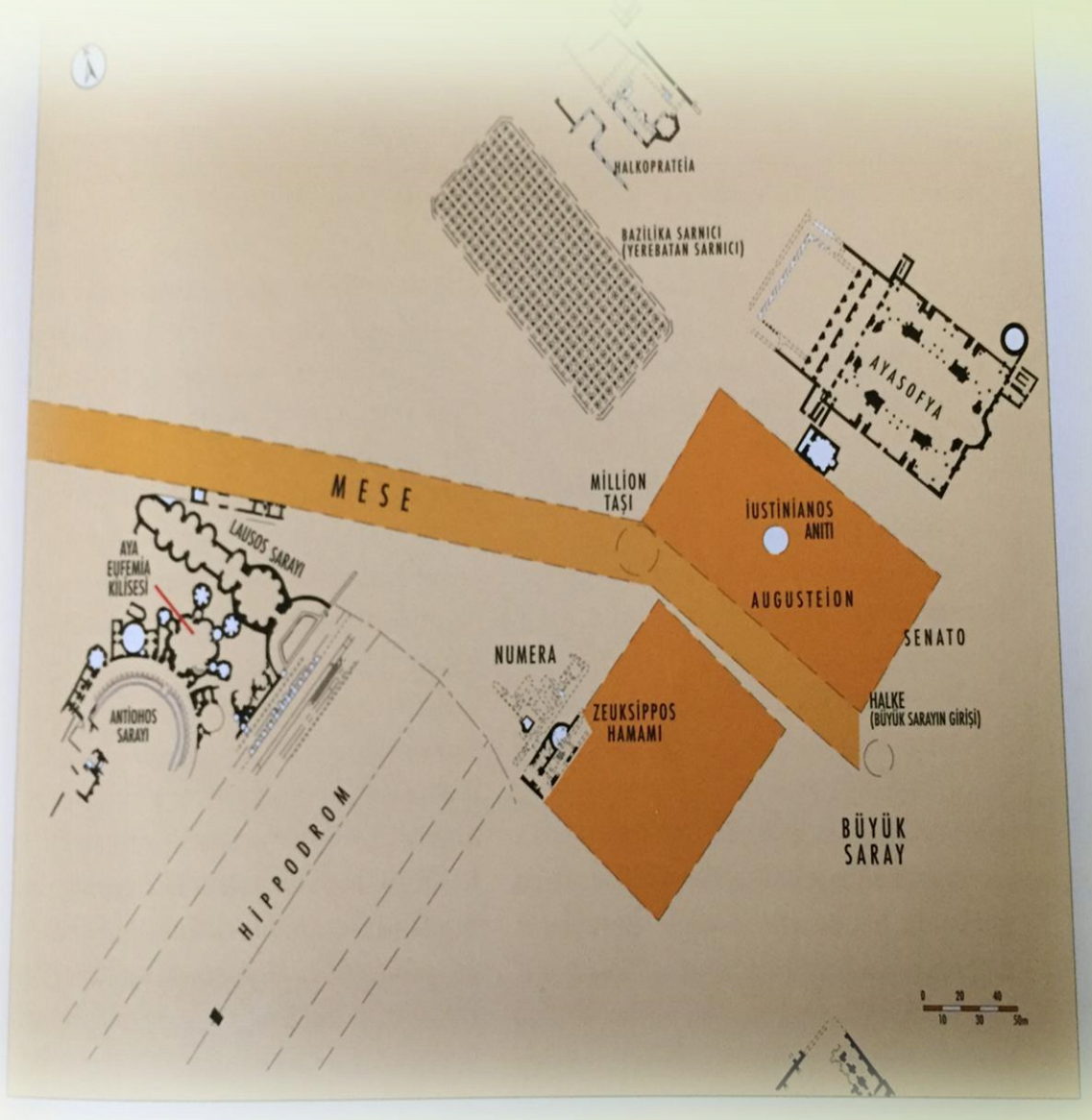


- The borders of the new capital were first determined during its establishment: **the walls of Byzantion, which passed through today's Cağaloğlu and included Sirkeci - Sarayburnu - Sultanahmet, were removed, and the city was expanded 2.5 kilometers to the west.**
- The expansion of the city area by approximately **four times** was a decision aimed at creating a magnificent capital of the future rather than the needs of the day.
- It is assumed that the Constantine walls, started from Cibali (Petrion) on the shores of the Golden Horn, passed around today's Fatih Mosque and reached the Marmara Sea from the west of Yenikapı.
- During the Constantine period, settlement was mainly concentrated on the eastern side of the peninsula, and the western part, which was included in the city area with the new walls, was sparsely populated.

- We do not have much information and archaeological data about the wall of Constantine today.
- It has been suggested that <u>the remains of a very strong wall unearthed during the Yenikapı excavations were part of this first wall of the city of Constantinople</u>.

the city center and surrounding buildings

- **city center**: the area around today's Sultanahmet Square
- The area where today's Topkapı Palace, **the acropolis** of the city, is located.
- **The Forum of Augusteion** surrounded by a portico was located in Sultanahmet Square, which is located on the south side of today's Hagia Sophia.
- **The Senate building** was built on the east side of the forum.
- **The Zeuksippos baths** were settled on the southwest side of the Forum of Augusteion, and further west was the Hippodrome, which stretched along the area west of today's Sultanahmet Mosque.
- **The imperial palace (Great Palace)** was started to be built adjacent to the east side of the **Hippodrome**.



Forum: a public square

Portico (Tr. revak): A covered, open-fronted, gallery-shaped architectural space adjacent to a building wall.

examples of porticoed buildings



Hippodrome: It was expanded.

in order:an engraving of the Hippodrome,a computer drawing of the Istanbul Hippodrome,and the area in today's Istanbul that corresponds to the Hippodrome (next to the Sultanahmet Mosque).





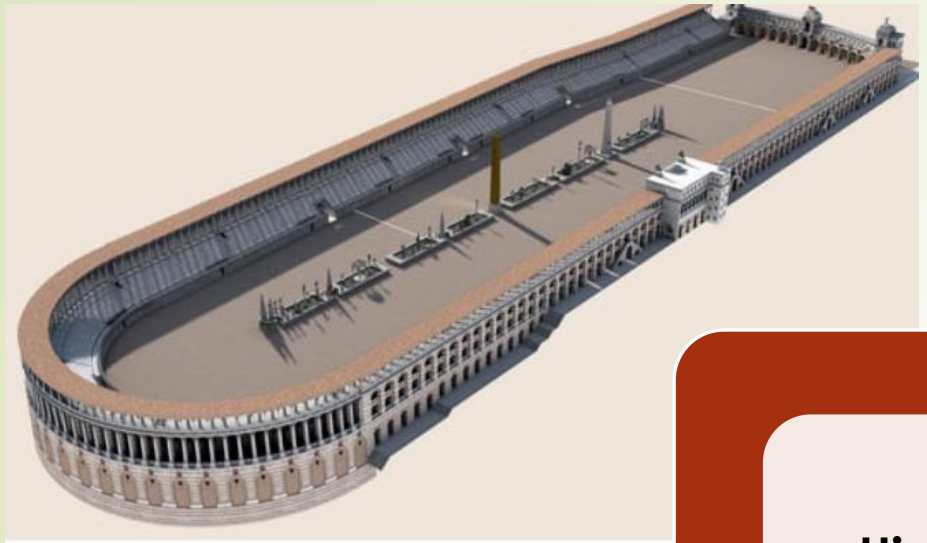


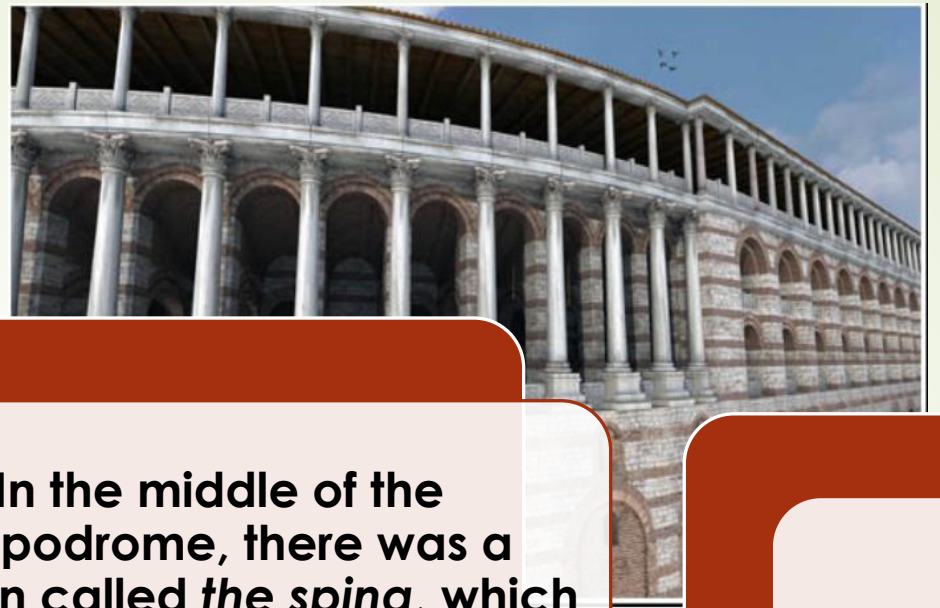
- **The Hippodrome was built during the reign of Septimius Severus and expanded and renovated during the reign of Constantine.**
- The Hippodrome, where horse-drawn chariot races, gladiator fights or various shows, entertainment and ceremonies were held, was among the important public structures of a Roman city.
- According to some researchers, the Hippodrome had a capacity of approximately 80.000 people.
- The Hippodrome extends approximately 450 meters, starting from the southwest of the Augusteion Square. The largest architectural remnant of the original architecture of the Hippodrome that has survived to the present day is the semicircular southern end (sphendone) built as an artificial terrace.
- At the other end to the north, there was a multi-storey, monumental entrance. On this entrance, there was a statue of a two-wheeled racing chariot pulled by four horses called quadriga, together with its driver. The bronze horses were smuggled to Venice during the Latin occupation of Constantinople (1204–1261) and are today located in San Marco..

Hippodrome

- The Hippodrome had an important role in the daily life of the people of Constantinople.
- The races, which were held with two-wheeled racing chariots pulled by four horses called **quadrigas**, were held between four parties called Greens, Blues, Reds and Whites, but mainly between the Blues and Greens.
- These parties, also in connection with the tradesmen's guilds, played certain roles in the social life of the city, such as civil defense and construction.
- Many of the rebellions that took place in Constantinople began in the Hippodrome and with the organization of these parties.
- The most important of these rebellions was the **Nika Revolt** against the Emperor Justinian in the sixth century.



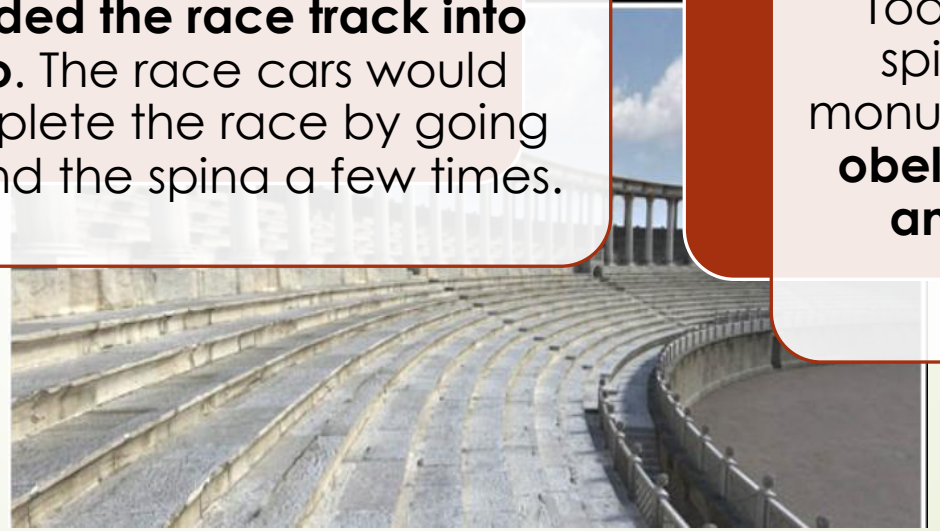




In the middle of the Hippodrome, there was a section called *the spina*, which divided the race track into two. The race cars would complete the race by going around the spina a few times.

Today, the location of the spina is marked by three monuments on it: **The Egyptian obelisk-The Serpent Column and The Walled Obelisk**





- https://byzantium1200.com/hipodrom.html
  - The illustration depicting the Byzantine hippodrome was prepared by Jonathan Bardill between 2008 and 2010 in connection with the Pera Museum exhibition Hippodrome and Atmeydani: A Stage for Istanbul's History (2010). The resulting computer model is the most detailed reconstruction of a Roman circus to date.

The Egyptian Obelisk (Obelisk of Theodosius)/Dikilitaş

- Constantine I decided to bring obelisks to Rome and the other to his new capital, but the project remained unfinished upon his death. His son Constantine II, who ascended to the throne, was able to bring the obelisk to Alexandria, and it was left to Julian (361–363) to bring the stone to Constantinople by sea. The obelisk was only erected in its place by Theodosius I in 390. This obelisk, which was shorter than its twin in Rome, was probably broken during transportation or during its erection, and a few meters of its lower part were cut off. The story of the erection of the stone in its place is depicted in the reliefs on the base of the obelisk.



Egyptian obelisk in the Hippodrome

- The other monument is **the Serpent Column** on the south side of the obelisk.
- Today, the column, where only three intertwined bronze snake bodies can be seen, was originally an altar on which three snakes carried a golden bowl on their heads. This altar, located in the Temple of Apollo in Delphi, where Byzas consulted the oracles before founding the city of Byzantion, was cast by melting the bronze weapons of the Persian soldiers in memory of the Greeks' defeat of the Persians in Plataea. Constantine took this altar, which has symbolic importance, from the Temple of Apollo and brought it to Constantinople.
- One of the heads of the snakes is currently exhibited in the Istanbul Archaeological Museums, Istanbul for Ages gallery.





- The third monument of the Spina that has survived to the present day is **the walled obelisk** on the sphendone side, built in the tenth century.
- The bronze coatings of this obelisk, which is completely covered with decorated bronze plates, were removed and melted by the Latins who occupied the city and used in casting weapons)





the serpent column and The Egyptian obelisk



The Egyptian obelisk and the Walled obelisk

3 monuments of the Spina in the Hippodrome

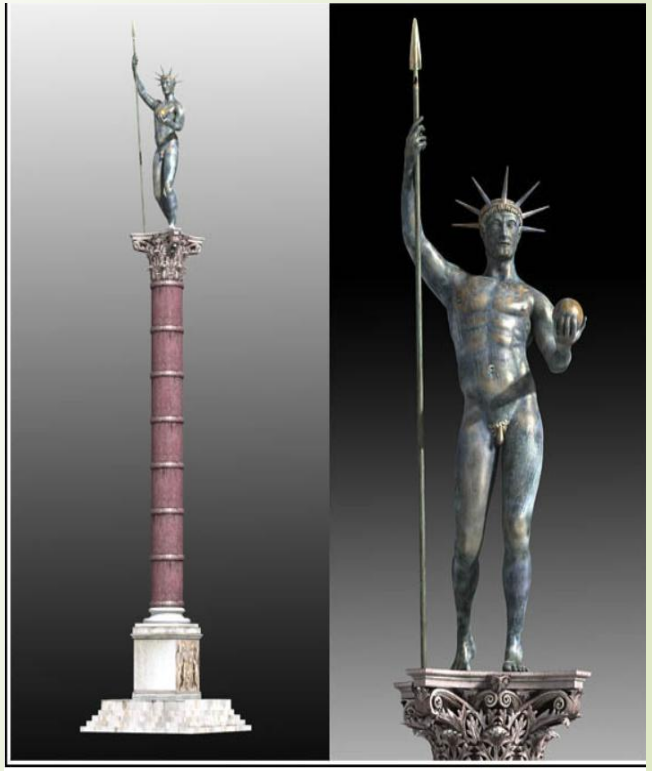
During the reign of Constantine, obelisks were brought and erected in the city.

- The Serpent Column, brought from Greece, was erected in the Hippodrome.
- Çemberlitaş (Column of Constantine) , brought from the Temple of Apollo in Rome, was placed in Constantine Square (Forum Constantinus)





The column of Constantine which still stands upright and is known as Çemberlitaş was erected in the center of the square.



This reconstruction shows the Column of Constantine before 1106.
This reconstruction is created for "Jonathan Bardill, Constantine: Divine Emperor of the Christian

Grand Palace/Great Palace (Magnum Palatium)



- The imperial palace, the Great Palace (Magnum Palatium), covers an area of approximately 100,000 square meters from the Hagia Sophia - Hippodrome line to the sea.
- **A palace complex** surrounded by walls.
- **It contained throne and official reception halls, living areas, churches, baths, guard barracks, gardens and playgrounds.**
- **The first structures that formed the core of this palace were built by Constantine** on the eastern side of the Hippodrome, in the area where the Sultanahmet Mosque is today.
- Later, some parts of the palace complex, which **expanded with various additions until the 11th century**, have survived to the present day. One of these is a mosaic-paved peristyle courtyard belonging to the later phases of the palace and unearthed during excavations between 1951-1954. These mosaics have been restored and are now open to visitors as the Mosaic Museum.





Mosaic samples from the grand palace

Constantine Forum (Çemberlitaş) and **Column of Constantine** on Mese Street

The Mese Street opened to an oval-shaped forum named after Constantine in today's Çemberlitaş, with an obelisk in the middle, and then continued westward.

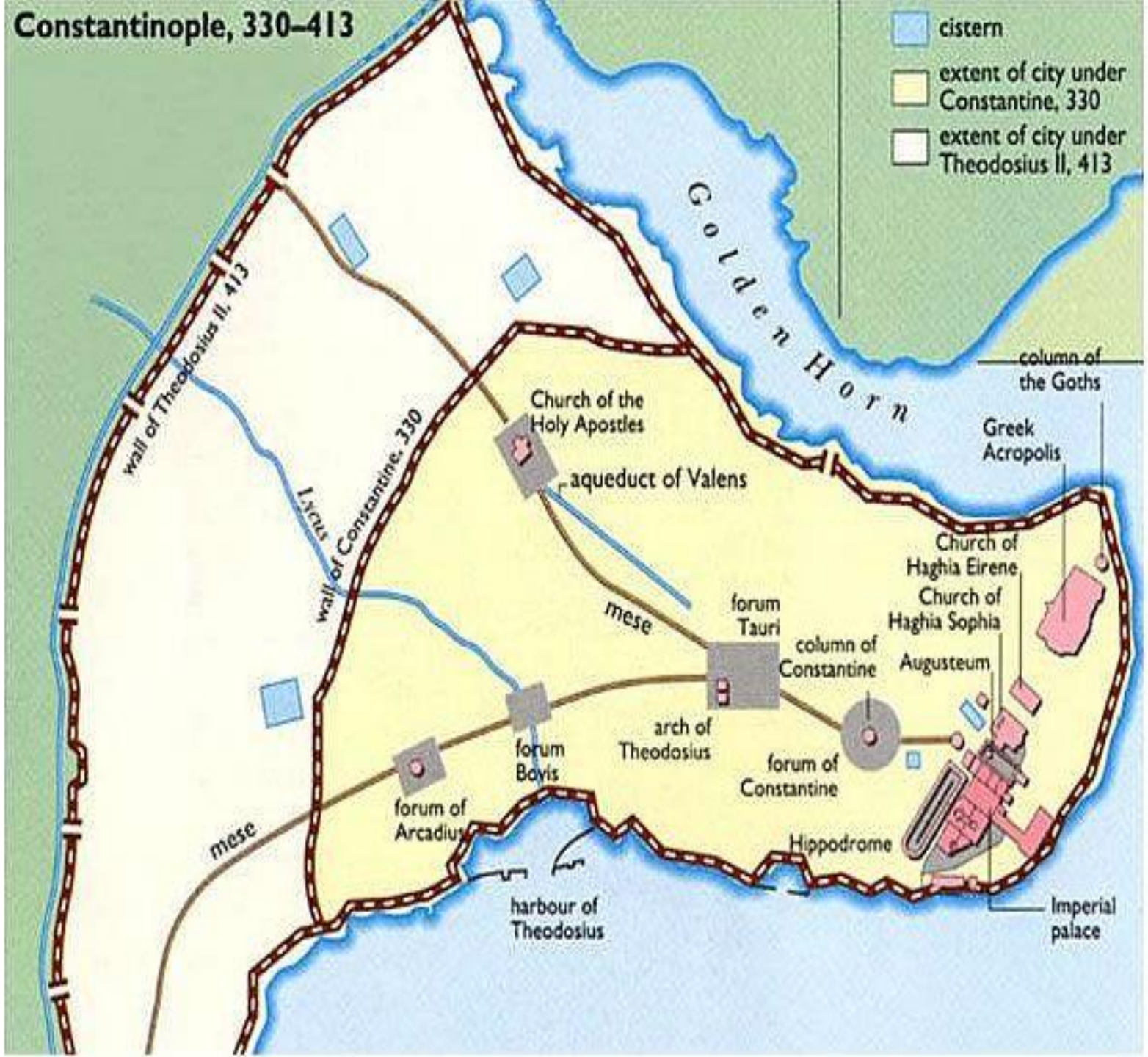
- On the monument-column made of prophyry granite (Çemberlitaş) in the middle of the forum, there was a statue of Constantine resembling the sun god Apollo.
- It is known that the streets and squares of the city of Constantinople were decorated with many statues.



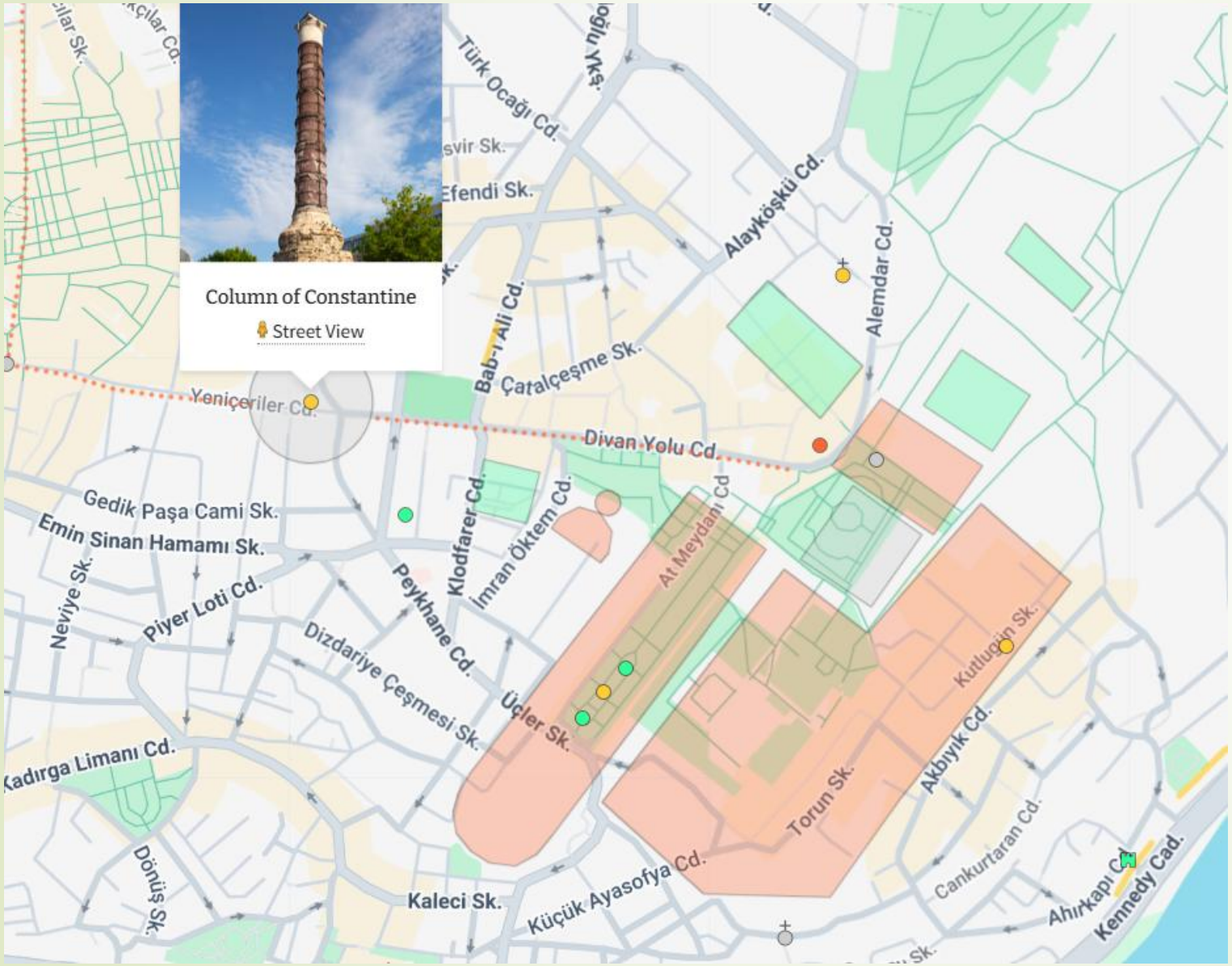
This reconstruction shows the Column of Constantine before 1106.
This reconstruction is created for "Jonathan Bardill, Constantine: Divine Emperor of the Christian Golden Age (Cambridge University Press, forthcoming)".

Constantine Forum
and
Constantine Column/Çemberlitaş Column




Constantinople, 330–413
cistern
extent of city under Constantine, 330
extent of city under Theodosius II, 413
Golden Horn
wall of Theodosius II, 413
wall of Constantine, 330
Lycus
Church of the Holy Apostles
aqueduct of Valens
column of the Goths
Greek Acropolis
Church of Haghia Eirene
Church of Haghia Sophia
Augusteum
mese
forum Tauri
column of Constantine
arch of Theodosius
forum Bovis
forum of Constantine
forum of Arcadius
mese
Hippodrome
harbour of Theodosius
Imperial palace

Map of Byzantine Constantinople | City of Constantine



Ports and Baths (at the time of the founding of Constantinople)

- When the city of Constantinople was founded, the ports at the entrance of the Golden Horn from Byzantium continued to be used. These were the Prosphorion and Neorion ports located in today's Sirkeci.
- These two ports at the entrance of the Golden Horn, which were closed to storms and currents, met the needs of the new capital for a while longer. However, as a result of the rapid population growth in the city, a need for a new port arose in the second half of the fourth century. (This port, built during the reign of Emperor Theodosius I (379–395), was located in today's Yenikapı, where the Bayrampaşa Stream, known as Lykos in the Byzantine period, flows into the sea. This port was unearthed during excavations carried out by the Istanbul Archaeological Museums in Yenikapı during the Marmaray works.)
- It is known that during the foundation phase of Constantinople, there were also baths, which were important public structures of ancient Greek and Roman cities.
- These baths, which constituted an important part of daily life in ancient cities, were public structures that had a social function beyond physical cleansing. When Constantine rebuilt the city, there were two old baths. One of them was the Achilles bath in Strategion in Sarayburnu. No archaeological traces of this bath can be found today, and it probably dates back to the Greek colonial period of the city.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?app=desktop&v=JzZp-qAYCZg

Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Empire

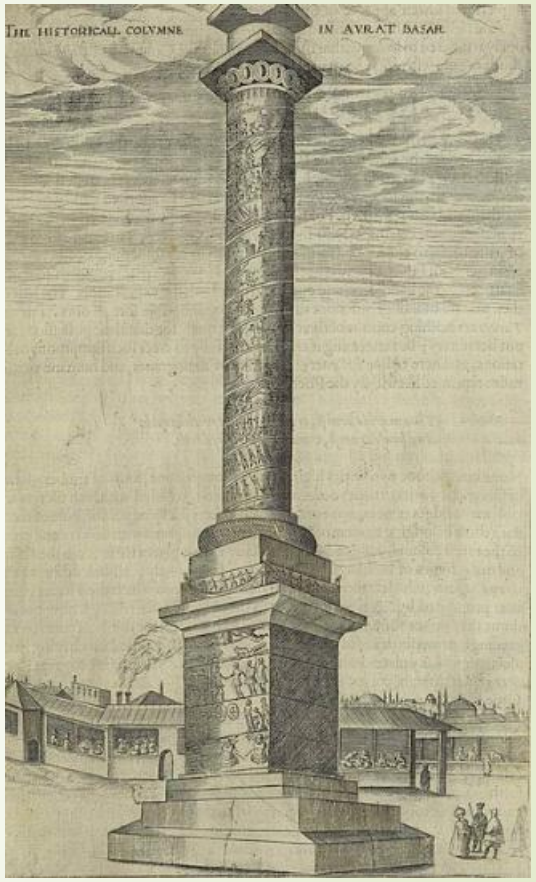
- When the last Roman Emperor Theodosius I died, the Roman Empire was divided into the Western Roman and Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Empires by his two sons (395).

- Theodosius' eldest son Arcadius became the first emperor of the Byzantine Empire.

  - The Western Roman Empire officially ended in 476. Emperor Romulus Augustulus was dethroned by the German King Odoacer.
  - The Eastern Roman Empire continued its existence as the Byzantine Empire until 1453 AD.

Period of Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Emperor Arcadius

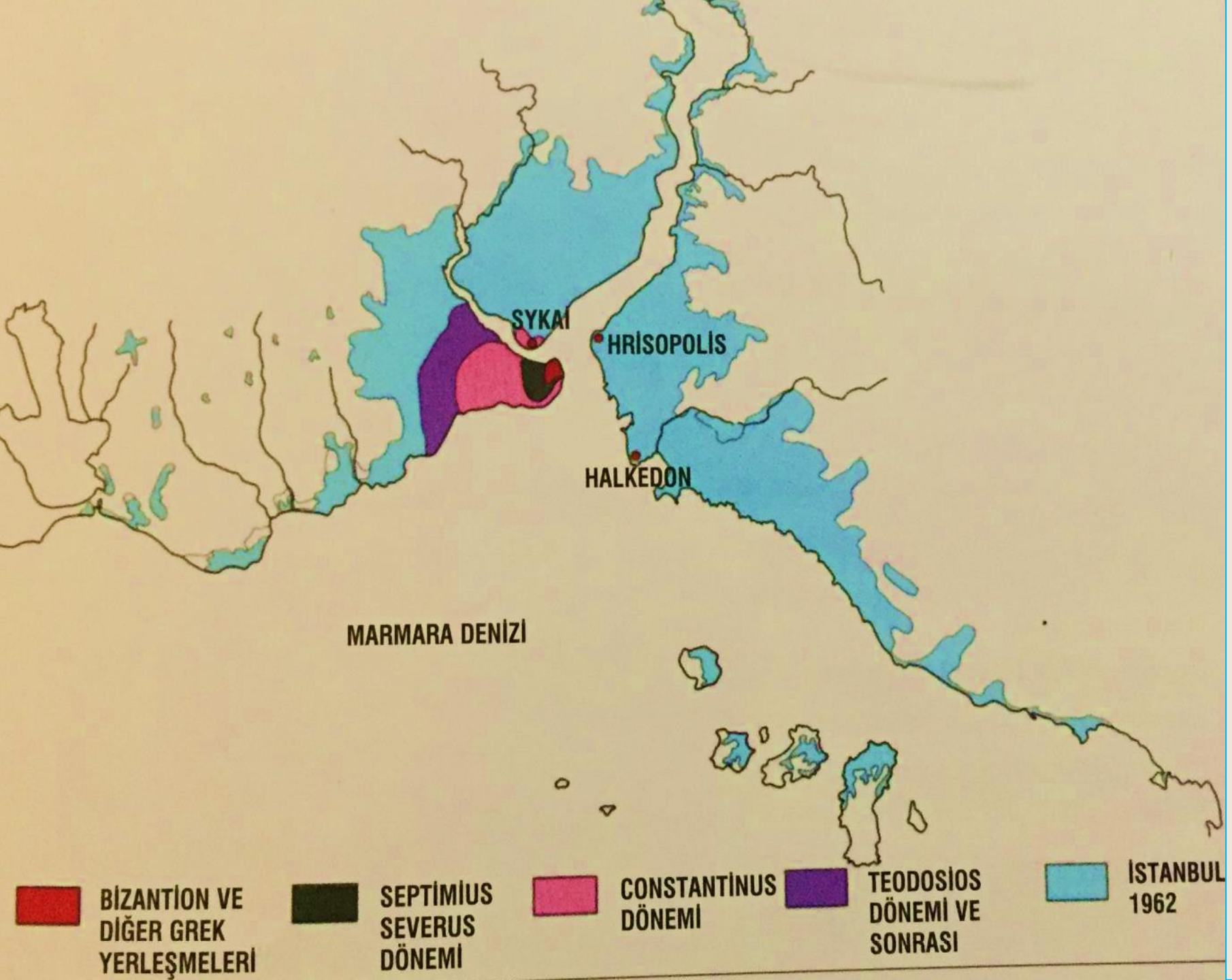
- Earthquakes in 398 and 402 during the reign of Arcadius
- The Column of Arcadius was erected in Haseki to commemorate the victory over the Visigoths.



Period of Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Emperor Theodosius II

- During the reign of Arcadius' son Theodosius II, the raids of the Hun Emperor Attila wore out Byzantium.

- After these raids in 447, another destructive factor was the earthquake
- With the impact of the Hun attacks, importance was given to defense systems (construction of walls)

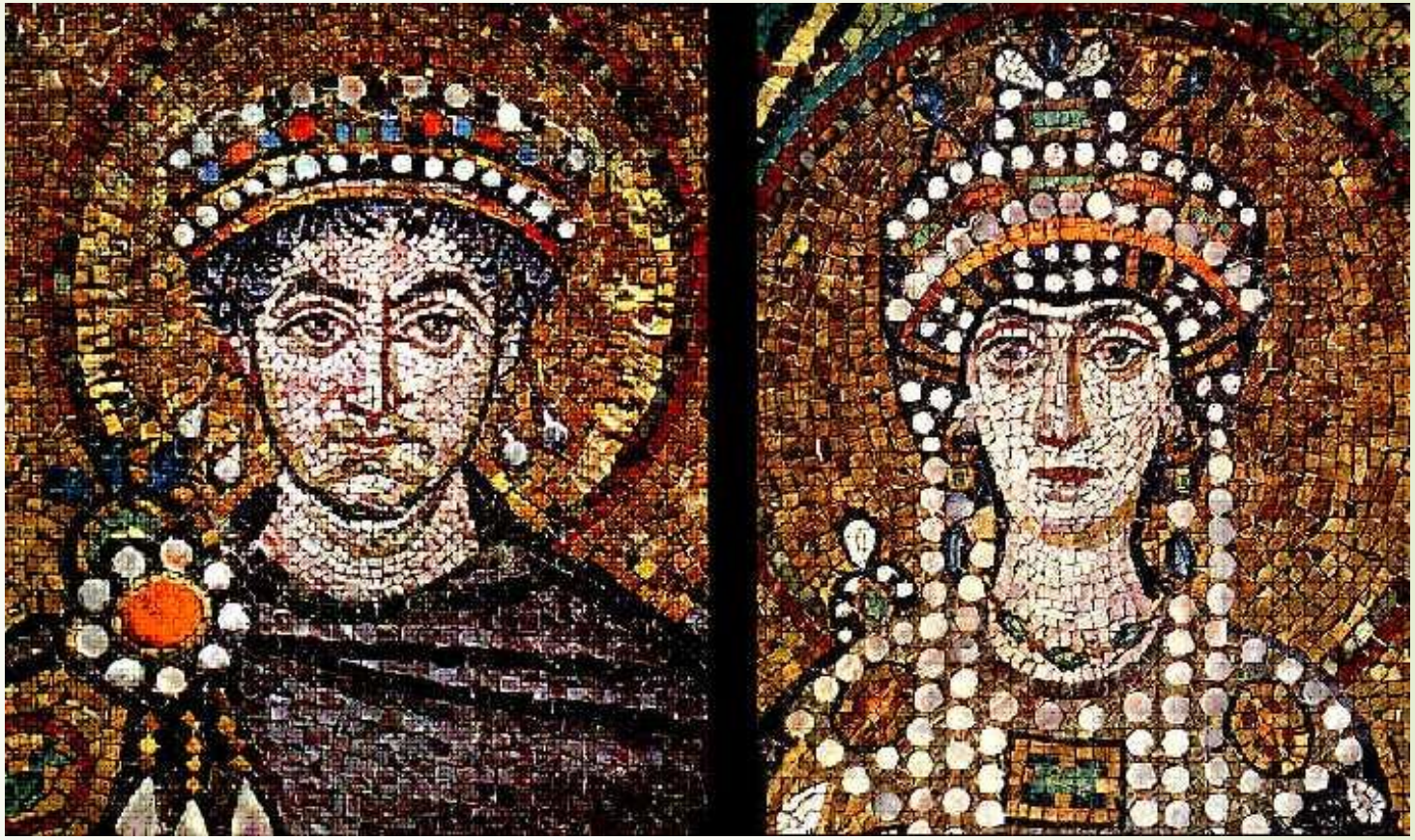


The city's expansion toward the west, or the land side:

- The **red** area represents Byzantium.
- When Roman Emperor Septimius Severus rebuilt the city, he expanded it up to the **black** area.
- When Constantine opened the city as the capital, he extended it toward the **pink** area.
- Finally, Theodosius II expanded it to the **purple** area.

The left edges of the colored zones show the boundaries of the city walls built during those periods.The walls that have survived to the present day are from the time of Theodosius II.

Period of Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Emperor Justinian



- The peak of the power of the early Byzantine Empire was the reign of Justinian and his wife, Empress Theodora (527-565).
- Istanbul experienced its golden age during this period.

Important names and important events of the Justinian Period

- Belisarios: General who conquered Spain and North Africa
- Prokopios: Historian (Justinian Wars, Buildings of Justinian I, Secret History)
- Nica Revolt (Blues and Greens)
- Reconstruction of the city (Hagia Sophia, Zeuxippos Bath, Marketplace, Great Palace, Senate, Basilica Cistern)
- Religious and civil structures on the Bosphorus and Golden Horn (Monasteries in Eyüp, churches in Arnavutköy and Çengelköy)

Nika Revolt (532)

- In 532, the Blues and Greens started the Nika revolt in the Hippodrome against the emperor. The uprising, which was also attended by the people, reached hundred thousand people and spread throughout the city.
- The Roman-style Christian church, the Hagia Sophia basilica, and the baths were destroyed.
- The dungeons were opened, parts of the palace and houses were looted. The rebel groups killed those who opposed them.
- Although things did not go well for Emperor Justinian at first and he made plans to escape, the speech made by his wife Theodora became a source of motivation for the emperor and eventually led to his decision to stay in the capital.
- On January 18, Justinian appointed General Belisarius and Mundus to the head of the troops and sent them to the Hippodrome to quell the unrest. The place where the Nika Revolt began, the great chariot racetrack, was also where the uprising was violently suppressed.
- After all exits were blocked by the soldiers, the crowd was trapped and then subjected to indiscriminate massacre. By the end of the day, an estimated 30,000 people had been killed.
- After the failed Nika Revolt, the influence of the circus groups was permanently eliminated.
- After consolidating his position, Justinian focused his efforts on rebuilding the capital.

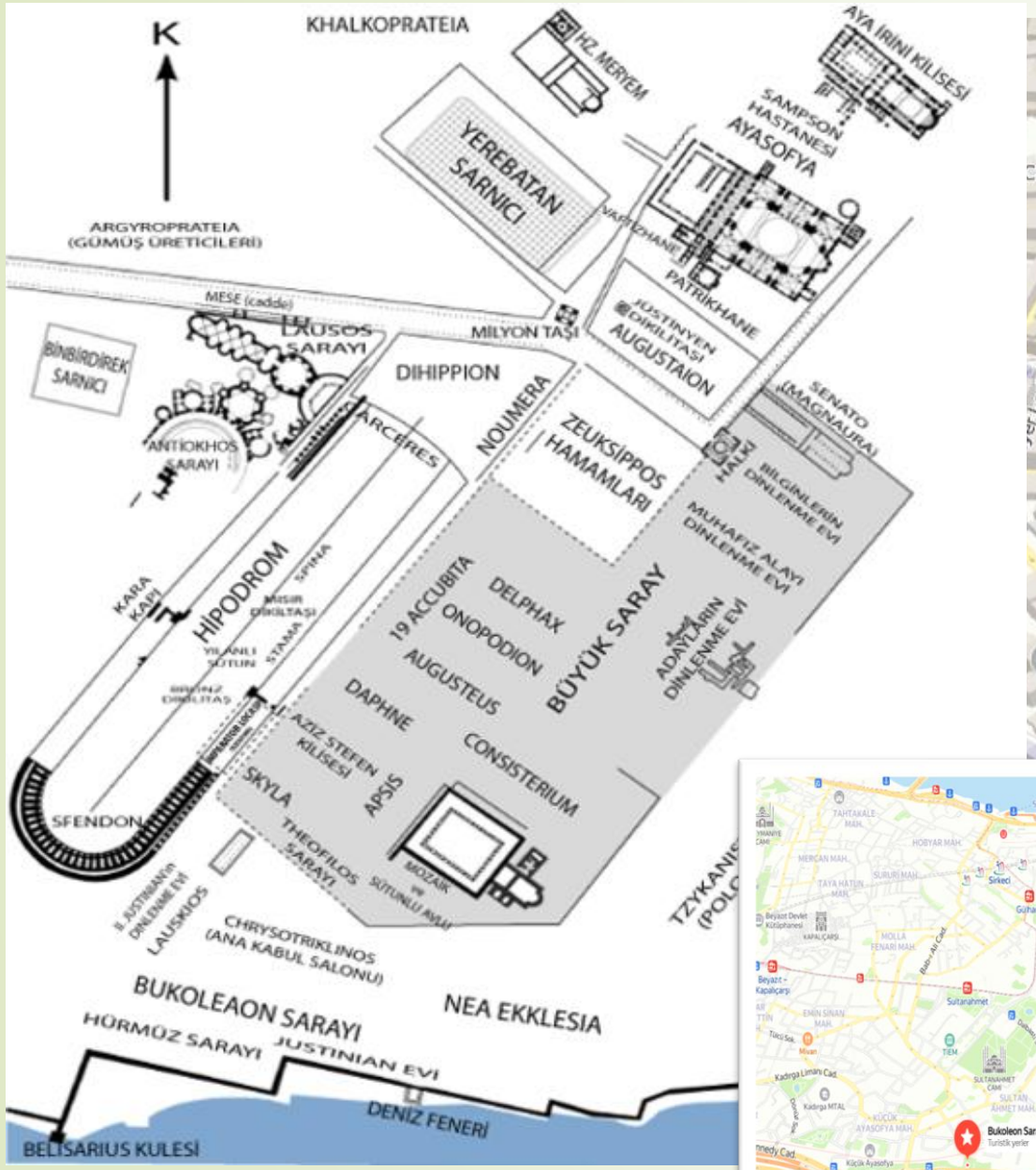
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MB2iUKAIPIs

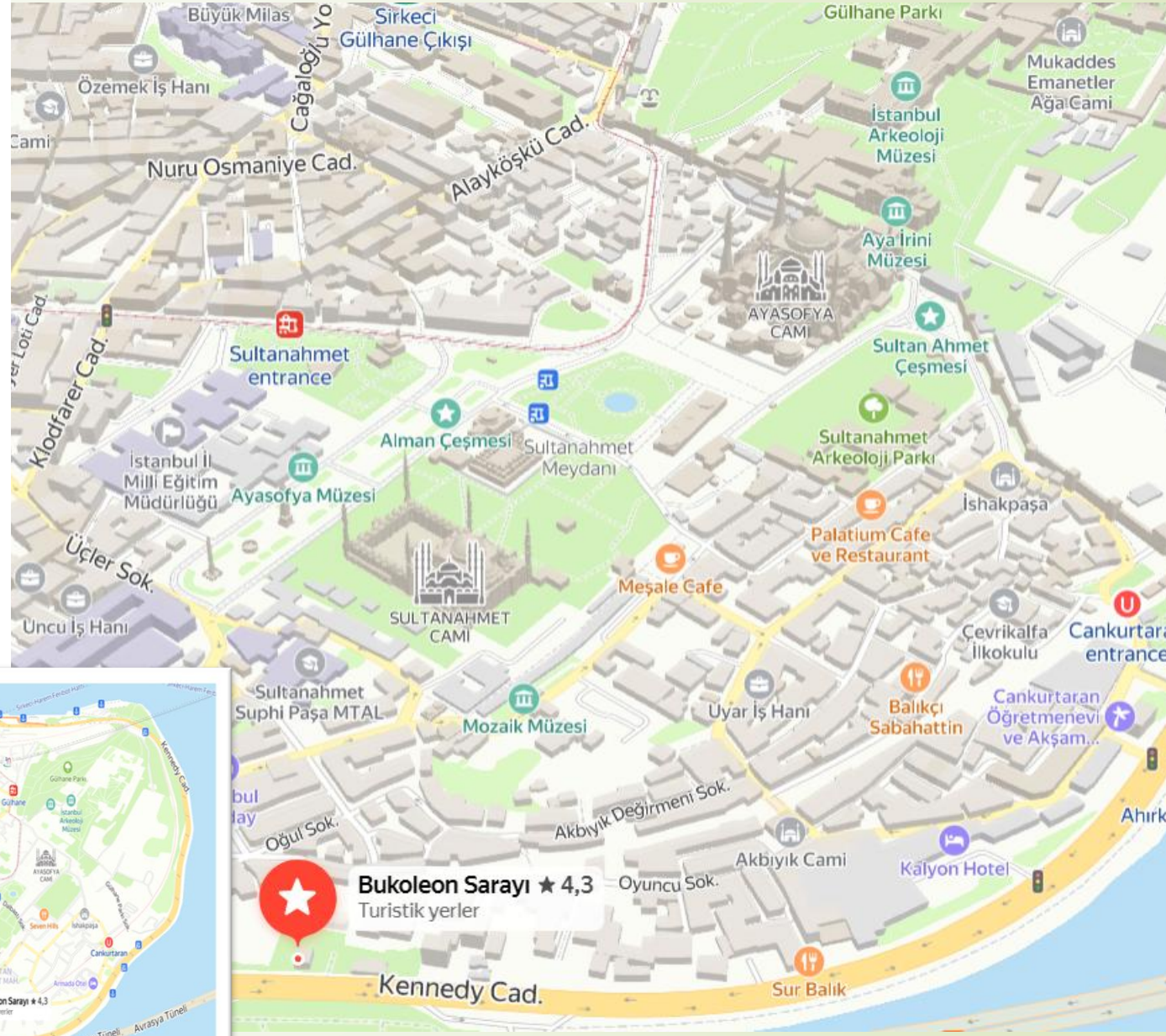
Reconstruction of the city after the uprising and earthquakes

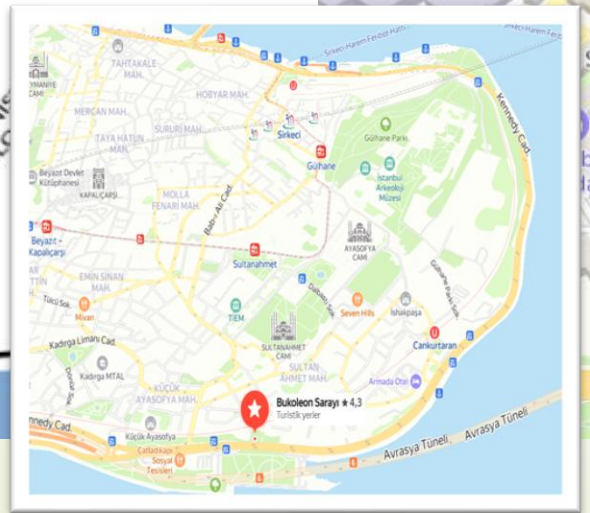
- After the Nika revolt, when a large part of the city was devastated by fire and an earthquake in 533, construction activities were initiated.
- The city was rebuilt within 5 years.

- The squares were added to the city form.
- Water was brought to the city with aqueducts.
- Baths and theaters were built.
- Art and trade progressed.
  - Chinese-Indian fabrics, jewelry, spices and raw silk were brought to Istanbul via Iran. Istanbul began to become a transit center for trade between East and West.
  - In addition, after silk cultivation and fabric decoration were learned and production began in Istanbul, the material wealth of Byzantium increased and its art developed.
- Important structures were built
  - The Little Hagia Sophia was built in 527, the Hagia Sophia and Hagia Irene Churches in 537, and the Basilica Cistern (Basilka water cistern- Yerebatan Sarnıcı) in 565.

CONSTANTINAPOLE







Architecture in Constantinople (Roman and Byzantine period)

Periods of Byzantine art and architecture, including Late Antiquity

(1) Early period (330-726): The period from the time Istanbul became the capital and the traces of traditional Roman imperial architecture were still visible in monumental structures such as Hagia Sophia.

(2) The period of iconoclasm-depiction (726-843): The period when depictions of humans, angels and holy people, other than geometric shapes, were not included in social life and the architecture that took shape accordingly after Christianity became the official religion, and these were destroyed.

(3) Middle period (843-1204): The period of military and financial revival when religious architecture was shaped by the church due to the dominance of the church institution despite the end of the depiction movement.

(4) The period of the Fourth Crusade-The First Latin Kingdom (1204-1261): The period when Catholics, mostly of Venetian origin, ruled. They seized Istanbul and established a kingdom in the city instead of serving the purpose of saving the lands considered sacred to Christianity.

(5) The last period (1261-1453): The period also known as the Palaiologan Dynasty, which left its mark on the period and began with the Byzantine administration recapturing Istanbul after fleeing to Nicaea and shifting the administrative center there during the invasion of the Fourth Crusade.

Architecture in Constantinople (Roman and Byzantine period)

The outline of changes in architecture from Rome to Byzantium

- Byzantine architecture, which was initially a continuation of the Roman Empire, has shown great differences over time, especially due to changes **in the religious field**. These differences are more **in proportions and dimensions** than in materials and workmanship.
- The monumental and propaganda-oriented structures of traditional Roman imperial architecture began to shrink with the spread of the new religion, Christianity.
- The theaters, stadiums and baths, which were indispensable elements of social life in Rome, could not find a place in the new order. When theaters were banned together with the Olympic games at the end of the 4th century, the public spaces where people could gather and have fun were restricted.
- After Christianity was accepted as the official religion at the end of the same century, baths were considered as places of evil by the clergy, and old habits were abandoned, and they began to be built on a much smaller scale and did not contain some of the features they had before.
- Another factor that changed in the new architecture was the **material size**. Brick continued to be one of the most frequently used materials. However, the large-sized bipedal bricks frequently seen in Rome were **used in smaller proportions in Byzantium**, almost half of which were used in larger proportions.

Architecture in Constantinople (Roman and Byzantine period)

Architects

- The least known factor in the field of architecture is architects.
- In an empire that ruled for more than a thousand years, there are about twenty architects whose names are known.
- The ones about whom the most information is received are those who worked on Hagia Sophia in particular. Anthemios of Tralles and Isidoros of Miletos have a special place among them. They designed and built Hagia Sophia. The earliest known architect among those whose names are known for their contributions to the restoration of Hagia Sophia is the young **Isidoros**, the nephew of Isidoros, one of the architects who **built the first Hagia Sophia.**

Architecture in Constantinople (Roman and Byzantine period)

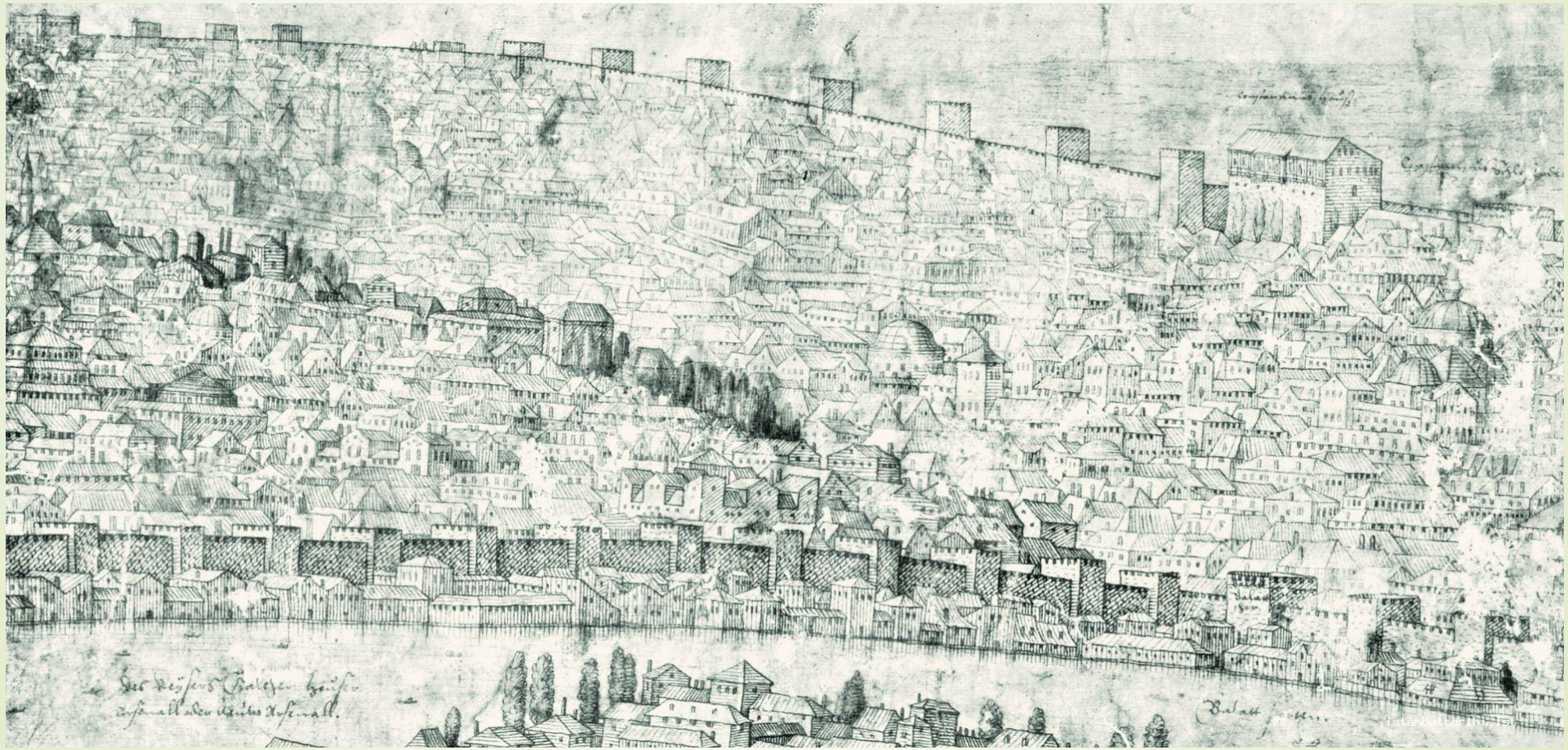
- Most of the architectural works dating back to the pre-Byzantine period have been destroyed by natural disasters and human.

- Since their parts were used as spolia, they have survived in buildings constructed in the following centuries.

- **Byzantine architecture is best seen in the field of religious architecture**. The most important reason for this is that religious buildings were in continuous use. The same is not true for the city walls that defended the city for about 1,000 years and the monuments such as water-related structures, squares, ports and obelisks that were indispensable elements of urban life.

MILITARY ARCHITECTURE

City Walls



WALLS

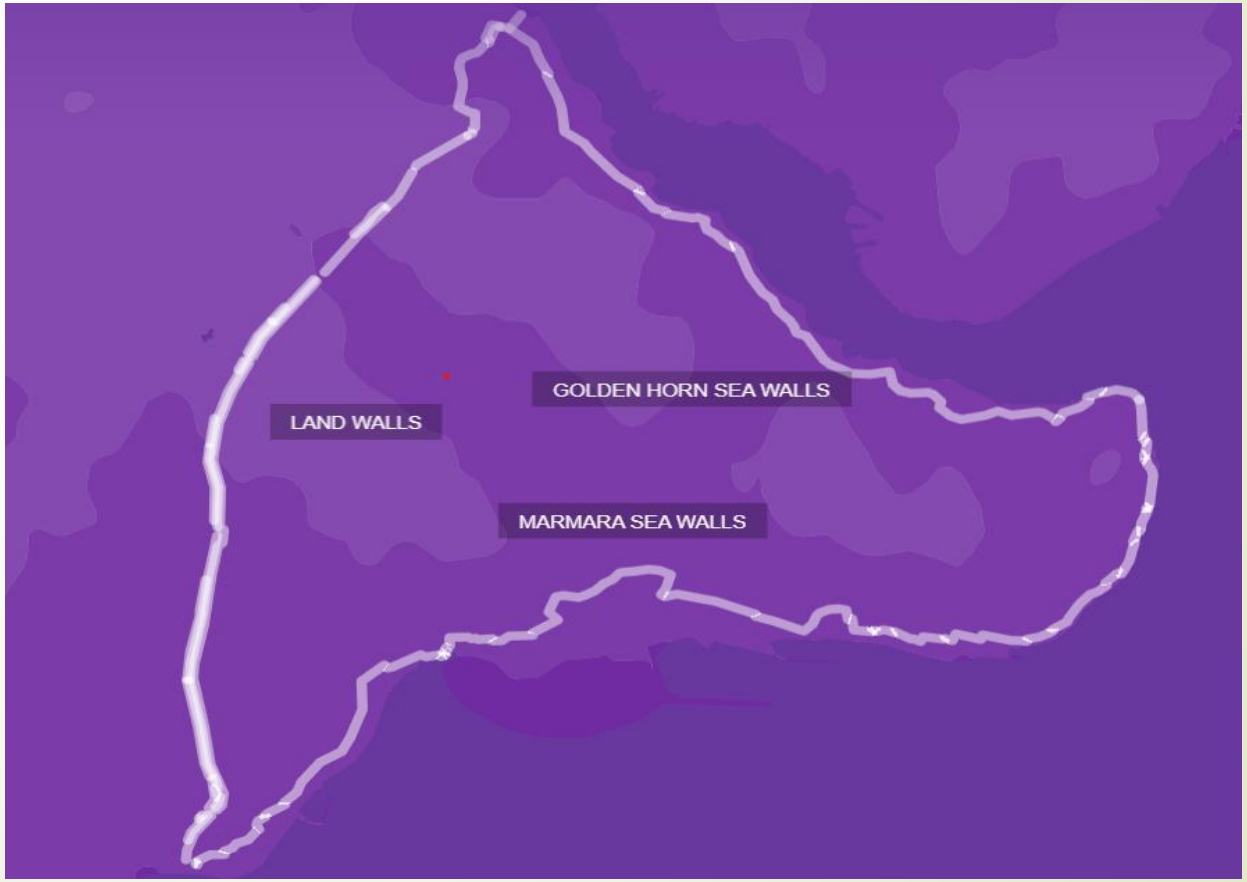
The most important part of the city defense is the walls.

Istanbul Walls:

Land Walls

Golden Horn Sea Walls

Marmara Sea Walls



LAND WALLS

- It is thought that the city of Byzantium had walls from the 7th century BC, immediately after its foundation.
- Septimius Severus, who captured the city in 195, punished the people of the city for opposing him and had the walls demolished, but he later had them repaired so as not to leave the city defenseless in later periods.
- The walls, which were damaged during the Gothic raids between 258-269, were repaired afterwards, and thus the city and its people remained unharmed.
- They were expanded by Emperor Constantine I in 328.
- Although the boundaries of the walls from the period of Constantine I are not known for sure, it is thought that they ended at a point called the İsa Kapısı or Ese Kapısı, which existed until 1509, in a place where Cerrahpaşa Hospital is today in Samatya. A section of the walls of Constantine I, which were thought to have disappeared without leaving a trace, was recently found during excavations in Yenikapı.



Land walls

- The large part of the land walls that can still be seen today was **built by Theodosios II** between 412-414.
- The southern end of the land walls, which were built in two rows, was at Yedikule-Mermerkule, and the northern end was at Haliç-Ayvansaray.
- It consists of three units: **the great wall** (main or back wall/wall), **the front wall** and **the moat**.
- The land walls were approximately 7 km long and had 96 towers, 10 main gates and 40 smaller entrances called military gates.
  - İsa Kapısı, Porta Aurea/Altın Kapı/Yedikule, Ksilokerbos (Belgradkapı), Pege (Silivrikapı), Mermerkule, Rhegium/Mevlevihane, Aziz Romanos/Topkapı, Pempton/Sulukule, Harisius/Edirnekapı, Eğrikapı, Blahenai)



Land walls

- The towers were built at intervals of 50-75 meters; their average height is 11 m and the average internal diameter of the polygonal ones is 5 m.

- At its originial construction, it was built with an alternating wall technique, usually four rows of brick and four rows of stone.
- The walls consist of several parts. These are the **body**, **the tower** and **the gate**, respectively.
- The towers mainly have quadrangular, hexagonal and octagonal shapes.





Golden Horn Sea Walls

- The length of the wall, which is located in a single row between the today's Sarayburnu and Ayvansaray districts, was approximately 6 km.
- There were 21 gates on the wall.
- Only a small section of the gates have survived to our time, some of which were used in the Ottoman period (such as Cibali, Ayakapı) continue to exist today, while the names of some of the demolished ones, such as Bahçekapı, endure as neighborhood names.



Marmara Sea Walls

- The Marmara section of the walls was approximately 8.5 km long and had 188 towers and 13 gates, much more than the land walls. Although some researchers have claimed that there were walls on the sea side from the earliest periods of the city, it seems not true due to the danger was expected from the land side and strong currents and winds made it difficult to land on the shores.
- The earliest information we have about the absence of walls on the sea shore dates back to 400 BC.
- Although it has been claimed that the sea walls were built by Constantine I, it is generally accepted that these walls were built in 439.
- Shortly after their construction, the walls were damaged in the earthquake of 447 and were repaired.
- The repair inscription was still remained in the Yenikapı area in the middle of the 19th century, but it was later lost. The winter of 763 brought polar cold, an area meters wide on the Black Sea coast froze, and the ice blocks that damaged the walls.
- The most extensive repairs on the sea walls were made during the reigns of Emperor Michael II and his son Theophilos, mainly between 829-842, as understood from the inscriptions on the walls.
- On February 12, 1332, a very violent storm caused great damage to the Marmara walls, destroying the sea walls and damaging the inner sections.



The most important duty of the Istanbul Walls during the Ottoman Period was to protect the city from unauthorized entry and fires that could spread inside. It also became a source of income by renting out certain sections.

https://istanbulsurlari.ku.edu.tr/tr/